

Session 7: Developing Talents into Strengths

Summary:

One of the most powerful lessons I've ever learned came from Peter Drucker. He said, "Strengthen your strength." Don't focus excessively on your weaknesses, and don't ignore the fact that your natural talents will shape what opportunities have the most potential for you. Picking an opportunity without first asking yourself if you have some degree of talent or gift that can help you excel in that area is a recipe for disaster.

To develop our talents into strengths, we must do something that is not natural - and that's to narrow our focus and narrow our expertise. The idea is to have real deep expertise in a particular area that's built on top of a natural talent or gift. That's where you find people making a lot of income. But this "narrowing" of skill is not intuitive for most people.

Here's an example of how to do this. Let's say you've decided that marketing is most suited to your talents. You don't want to spend most of your time learning about all the different areas of marketing - direct sales, branding, social media, etc. Instead, spend about 80% of your time focusing on that segment of marketing that is both most suited to your natural talents and most suited to the growth of the industry.

Let's say you get into marketing and you try direct response marketing, and you try social media, and you see that you're better at the social media stuff... and you also see that social media as an industry is really exploding. It would make perfect sense for you to narrow your focus on social media. Don't get trapped in a cul-de-sac because you're getting interested in something that's a dinosaur and is going to be extinct in 5 or 10 years. Be smart.

A strength is really an expertise. I define expertise as knowledge + experience. As you put more of these two together, the more valuable you become.

To turn your talents into strengths, there's another element... "practice." Most people view practice as something other than "really doing it." But if you consider a spiritual practice, like meditation, it brings to mind a completely different approach. In this other approach, practice counts. It's the real thing. It's critical.

Here's another idea: For the next 10-20 years, you'll get a lot of leverage if you continually improve your communication skills on all levels. Improve your vocabulary, your ability to communicate with precision, persuade, use metaphor and story, and speak in front of groups of people. No matter your strength, communication will make it much more powerful. The reason is because while the world is getting more complicated, most people take too long to get to the point and aren't razor sharp about their message. When you do this, you "lose" people, even if you're an expert on the topic. And when you lose people, opportunities shut down.

So get a book by Rudolf Flesch called *How to Write, Speak, and Think More Effectively*. It'll help you learn how to get to the point quickly in your communications. Also study direct response copywriting. These copywriters are paid to communicate directly and get a response. The books I recommend here are David Ogilvy's *Ogilvy on Advertising* and Claude Hopkins' *Scientific Advertising* and *My Life in Advertising*. These are classics and will teach you how to think and communicate better.

One final thought:

Adam Smith observed that one person alone doing all the different tasks necessary to create something wasn't nearly as efficient as getting more people involved, each focusing on only one part of the total process. This allows each person to do what they are best at, and it also allows each person to not spend their time doing tasks that they simply don't have a natural knack for. So part of developing your talents into strengths is working with other people who can do the things you're not great at. For example, if you're an amazing innovator and spontaneous, you're probably going to want to partner with someone who is good at organizing and planning and keeping projects on track.

Exercise:

1. What's the connection between your gift or talent and the future opportunity that you're going to pursue? (In terms of a strength you'll need to develop)?
2. What do you need to practice in order to build your talent into a strength that will help you create value in that future opportunity?
3. What do you need to do to make sure you practice every single day?
4. What can you do right now to improve your communication skills?